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Pope assails Trump on Iran

Pontiff's criticisms 'an inflection point' for Christians in US

By Bill Barrow
ASSOCIATED PRESS

Donald Trump is accustomed to criticism from coast to coast — Democrats, disaffected Republicans, late-night comedians, massive protests. Yet in his second presidency, Trump's most influential American critic doesn't live in the country but at the Vatican.

It's an unprecedented situation, with the first American pope directly assailing the American president over the war in Iran, where a fragile ceasefire took hold this week. The announcement came after Pope Leo XIV declared that Trump's belligerence was "truly unacceptable."

Never before has the relationship between Washington and the Vatican revolved around two Americans — specifically, a 79-year-old politician from Queens and a 70-year-old pontiff from Chicago. They come from the same generation and share some common cultural roots yet bring jarringly distinct approaches to their positions of vast power. And the relationship comes with risks for both sides.

"They're two white guy boomers but they could not be

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■ With the ceasefire in Iran still shaky, U.S. and Iranian negotiators are heading to Pakistan for high-level talks. **Nation & World, Page B4**



Driver Gus Valenciano hops into his cab before leaving for a trip out of the Moran Transportation Corp. in Elk Grove Village on Wednesday. The company has felt the weight of the surge in fuel prices amid the war in Iran. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Nothing in the tank

Gas prices spike 25% in Chicago since start of US-Israel war with Iran

By Tess Kenny
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

On any given day, Moran Transportation Corp.'s fleet of trucks covers some 34,000 miles.

Though the 46-year-old Elk Grove Village trucking company prides itself on being more efficient than ever, it still takes a whole lot of diesel to see a day's work through.

Those 34,000 miles start to add up, especially when fuel prices surge — let alone during an unprecedented disruption to the global energy market.

For weeks now, the war that the U.S. and Israel launched against Iran in late February has destabilized worldwide energy production, culminating in what industry leaders are saying is the largest disruption to the global oil market in history. And while the conflict lies halfway around the planet, Illinoisans are feeling the weight of the supply shock.

Since the start of the war, the average cost of gas has gone up more than 25% in Chicago. That stat, which reflects the change in prices from February to March,

is the single biggest month-over-month increase on record for the city, according to a Tribune analysis of data from the U.S. Energy Information Administration.

The average cost of diesel has spiked to an even greater degree, going up nearly 40% in the Midwest over the past six weeks. Nationally, fuel prices are higher than they've been in four years, since Russia invaded Ukraine. The shock, which is affecting most countries, has sent global leaders scrambling to contain the rising costs while, locally, gas giveaways

offering a moment's relief from the surge have cropped up from the city to Indiana.

The impact spans everyday drivers filling up their tanks ahead of work to companies like Moran Transportation that rely on affordable fuel to turn a profit. And experts warn the pressure will only compound the longer the conflict stretches on, something that's increasingly possible despite a shaky two-week ceasefire.

Already, Moran Transportation

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Santo Nieves, center, picks items to fill a client's order at the Pilsen Food Pantry on Chicago's South Ashland Avenue on April 1. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

More than 16K immigrants in state may lose food assistance in coming months

By Laura Turbay
and Madeline King
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Roughly 16,000 immigrants, including victims of domestic violence, may lose access to crucial food assistance in Illinois as a result of federal eligibility changes that took effect April 1.

Immigrants — including refugees, asylum-seekers and survivors of human trafficking — are no longer eligible for the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, commonly known as SNAP. Thousands are expected to start losing benefits upon their semiannual

redetermination.

The tighter restrictions on food and health assistance benefits are dictated by the "One Big Beautiful Bill," the Trump administration's economic policy package passed by Congress in July. As a result, thousands of immigrants relying on the benefits now face the risk of hunger and sickness, experts say.

"I mean, fundamentally, this means that people are gonna go hungry," said Nolan Downey, senior director of policy at the Greater Chicago Food Depository, calling the recent budget bill's changes to SNAP eligibility for immigrants a "dramatic depar-

ture from long-standing policy in this country."

Immigrants who will remain eligible for SNAP are certain green-card holders, Cuban and Haitian entrants and those residing under the Compact of Free Association, among other categories of lawfully permanent residents. Immigrants without legal status have never received SNAP benefits.

For many immigrants who come to the U.S. lawfully, food assistance is crucial, experts say.

"These are folks who, when

See **FOOD** on Page A4

Jury awards \$70M in Abbott formula cases

Punitive damages pile on after mothers allege suburban company's product sickened babies

By Lisa Schencker
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A Cook County jury on Friday decided that Abbott Laboratories should pay \$17 million in punitive damages — on top of \$53 million in compensatory damages awarded a day earlier — in four cases in which mothers alleged the company's formula for premature infants caused their babies to become severely ill.

The decision Friday came at the close of a monthlong trial that was the first against Abbott in an Illinois state court over whether its formula for babies born prematurely causes a devastating intestinal disease called necrotizing enterocolitis. Known as NEC, it's an often-fatal illness in which the lining of the intestine becomes inflamed and dies.

The trial has been closely

watched because of its potential implications for both north suburban-based Abbott and families of premature babies nationwide.

Abbott faces more than 1,700 similar lawsuits across the country over its formula for premature infants.

Four Chicago-area mothers — Antonia Mendez, Casie Thompson, Kara Sharpe and Eboni Williams — brought the cases that went to trial together starting last month in Cook County Circuit Court. Their babies were all born at local hospitals before 32 weeks' gestation between 2012 and 2019, and all developed NEC after consuming Abbott's Similac Special Care, a formula for babies born prematurely that's offered in hospitals.

See **ABBOTT** on Page A4

NATION & WORLD Artemis safely splashes down

Artemis II's astronauts returned from the moon with a dramatic splashdown in the Pacific on Friday to close out humanity's first lunar voyage in more than a half-century — one that broke records and put eyes on parts of the universe previously unseen.

SPORTS Cubs waste gem from Imanaga

Pitcher Shota Imanaga may be the best candidate to step into the ace role after right-hander Cade Horton went down with a season-ending injury, but on Friday, the Cubs wasted six no-hit innings from the 2024 All Star in a 2-0 loss to the Pirates at Wrigley Field.

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